

The AI Landscape

What Actually Matters Right Now

A plain-English guide — no jargon, no hype, just what you need to know.

AI Assistants

Ask questions, analyze documents, write drafts, brainstorm. Your new thinking partner.

	ChatGPT START HERE All-around: writing, analysis, images, code	Free / \$20
	Claude START HERE Long docs, careful analysis, natural writing	Free / \$20
	Gemini by Google Gmail, Docs, Calendar, YouTube integration	Free / \$20
	Copilot by Microsoft Word, Excel, Outlook, Teams, PowerPoint	Incl. w/ M365

AI Search

Get answers, not links. AI reads the web for you and gives you sourced answers directly.

	Perplexity MOST IN-DEPTH Deep research with sourced citations. Best for thorough answers.	Free / \$20
	Grok on X.com MOST REAL-TIME Live posts, trending topics, breaking news as it happens.	Incl. w/ X Premium
	ChatGPT Search Web search built into ChatGPT. Good general-purpose.	Incl. w/ ChatGPT
	Google AI Overviews AI answers at the top of your Google searches. Already live.	Free

AI Automation

Work that happens without you. Connect apps, automate tasks, answer phones 24/7.

	Zapier START HERE Connect 7,000+ apps: "When X happens, do Y"	Free / \$20
	Make Visual workflow builder for complex automations	Free / \$9
	AI Voice Agents Answers calls, books appointments, 24/7	\$50-200/mo
	AI Email Assistants Drafts replies in your style, you approve	\$50-100/mo

AI Content Creation

Create presentations, images, study guides, and slide decks in minutes.

	NotebookLM by Google TRY THIS Upload docs → get study guides, FAQs, podcast-style audio	Free
	Gamma Describe a deck → it builds polished slides for you	Free / \$10
	ChatGPT Images DALL-E Create any image from a text description	Incl. w/ Plus
	Gemini Images by Google Image generation inside Gemini & Google tools	Free / \$20

Start Here (This Week)

- 1 **Create a free ChatGPT account** at chatgpt.com
- 2 **Set up Custom Instructions** — tell it your role and how you like answers
- 3 **Use it for 5 real tasks** instead of Google or doing it manually
- 4 **Try Perplexity** (perplexity.ai) for your next research question
- 5 **Pick one repetitive task** and ask: "How would I automate this?"

The Honest Truth

- ✓ **You need 2-3 tools, not 50.** Start with ChatGPT + Perplexity. Add more only when you hit a limit.
- ✓ **AI won't replace you.** But someone who uses AI will work faster than someone who doesn't.
- ✓ **Tools change every few months.** Learn how to work with AI, not which button to click.
- ✓ **Start small.** One tool. One task. This week. That's all it takes.